

LIN7209 – Syntax

Agreement

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Plan for today

- Agreement basics building on Phase Theory.
- Long Distance agreement in Tsez (Polinsky & Potsdam, 2001).

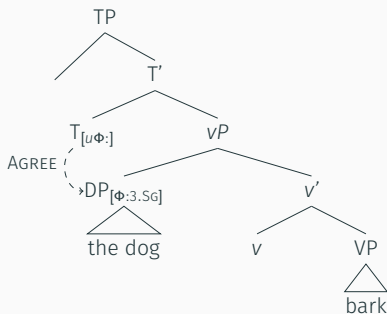
Agreement basics

Subject-verb agreement

- Agreement is often understood as a **syntactic relation** established between subject and verb.
- (1) a. The dog bark*(s).
b. The dogs bark(*s).
c. The children laugh(*s).
d. The sheep bleat(s).
- In Class 1, we saw that Agreement:
 - Is sensitive to “abstract” **features** (number, person, gender...) that need not be overtly realized;
 - May target **non-subjects** (e.g. objects), and even sometimes “**track**” **specific features** instead of specific syntactic positions.
- This all suggests Agreement is a **very general mechanism** in Syntax.

Agree as a Probe-Goal relationship

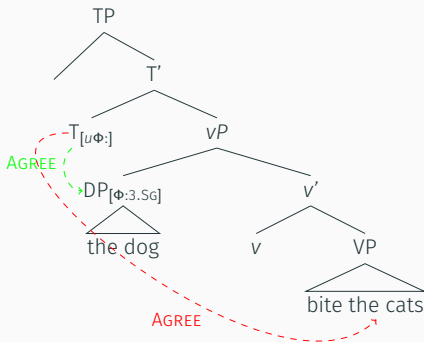
- Successful Agreement is a condition for **grammaticality**, and a potential **trigger for movement and Case assignment**.
- AGREE involves two kinds of elements: a **Probe** looking for specific features, and one or more **Goals** bearing these features.¹
- For instance, in English T is a Probe looking for Φ -features, and DPs like *the dog* bear Φ -features.



¹Here "Goal" has nothing to do with the same-name Θ -role!

Downward probing

- Probes normally look for Goals within their C-Command domain (i.e. **downward**).²
- They'll AGREE with the **highest** Goal (w.r.t. C-Command) bearing the right features.³

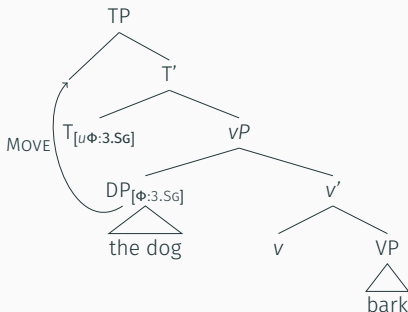


³Zeijlstra (2012) in fact adopts a “reverse” perspective.

³Though there’s sometimes Multiple AGREE...Ura (1996) and Hiraiwa (2001).

Agree, movement and Case

- Once a Probe has found a Goal, it **copies its features**.
- The Probe may also **move the Goal to its Specifier**.
 - English T for instance, attracts its Goal (the subject) to Spec-TP. T is said to have an “**EPP**”-feature (for Extended Projection Principle), forcing Spec-TP to be filled, and so forcing movement.
 - **T also assigns Case** to the subject (in English, NOMINATIVE).

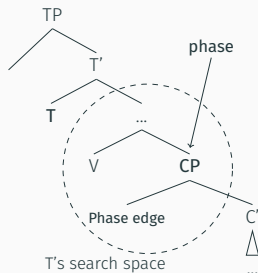
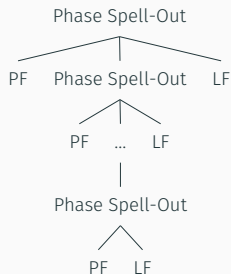


Types of movement

- Two general kinds of movements can be identified cross-linguistically. Both can be seen as AGREE-driven. But they exhibit two relatively stable, and crucially distinct, clusters of properties.
- **A-movement** (e.g.: subject movement; raising; unaccusatives; passives). Local, creates new antecedents for binding, island-insensitive.
- **$\bar{A}$ -movement** (e.g.: *wh*-movement, topicalization). Unbounded,⁴ does not create new antecedents for binding, island-sensitive.
- Recall movement is just INTERNAL MERGE, which creates two copies of the moved element.
 - If the **higher** copy gets pronounced, we get **overt** movement.
 - If the **lower** copy gets pronounced, we get **covert** movement. Even if it's invisible, it should be diagnosable using the above binding, and island-sensitivity criteria (among others).

⁴**Not the case in Tsez though**, in which $\bar{A}$ -operations appear uniformly clause-bounded.

Agree and locality



- Agreement is thought to be relatively local: the Probe cannot look “too far” down.⁵ Here’s why.
- CPs (and sometimes vPs) constitute “**phases**” sending everything they dominate but their Spec to LF and PF (“**Spell-Out**”).
- Spell-Out makes the inside of phasal projections **almost entirely opaque to upper Probes**. Only their Spec (Spec-CP, Spec-vP), called “**phase edge**” remains accessible. This is the **Phase Impenetrability Condition (PIC)**.⁶

⁵We’ll see later this semester how this does not preclude unbounded $\bar{A}$ movement.

⁶Chomsky, 2000, 2001

Summary

- Agreement is linked to **feature valuation**, **Case assignment**, and goes beyond classic subject-verb dependencies.
- Agreement goes **downward**, but is **bounded** by phasal projections (e.g. CP). It can access phase edges though (e.g. Spec-CP), and also the phase as a whole (e.g. the entire CP).
- Agreement often triggers **movement** to the Spec of the Probe, e.g. movement of subjects to Spec-TP (A-movement); movement of *wh*-phrases to Spec-CP ($\bar{A}$ -movement).

Long Distance Agreement in Tsez

Ergative-Absolutive case system

- In English, subject and objects receive different **case markings**. The subject will be NOMINATIVE, and the object ACCUSATIVE.
- Crucially, English Case assignment does not depend on transitivity: the subject of a verb, transitive or not, will be invariably NOM.

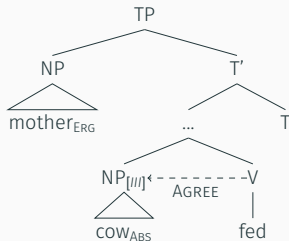
(2) a. {He_{NOM}/*Him_{ACC}} smiled.

b. {He_{NOM}/*Him_{ACC}} likes {*she_{NOM}/her_{ACC}}.

- In ERGATIVE-ABSOLUTIVE languages, this is not the case: you'll basically say *he smiled*, but also *him likes she*!
- **The subject of an intransitive and the object of a transitive are marked with the ABSOLUTIVE case, and the subject of transitives bear ERGATIVE.**
- Tsez, Basque, Georgian, Mayan, Tibetan, Sumerian, and many Indo-Aryan languages are ERGATIVE-ABSOLUTIVE.

Tsez arguments

- In Tsez, **verbs agree with their absolutive argument**, i.e. with their object if they are transitive.
- P&P show evidence⁷ that in transitive structures, the ergative argument (subject) C-Commands the absolutive argument (object).



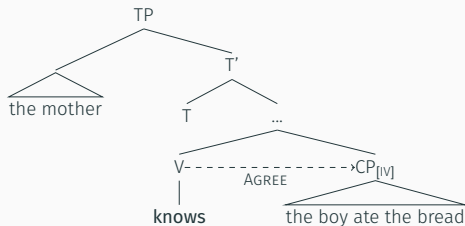
- To make things easier to process, I'll use head-initial trees from now on, even if Tsez has head-final Vs and Ts, as shown in the above tree.

⁷Superiority effect in double *wh*-questions; case assignment in control structures; anaphor binding; cross-clausal coreference.

Starting with relatively standard Agreement...

- (3) enir [užā magalu bāc'ruḷi] r-iyxo
mother [boy bread.III.ABS ate].IV IV-know
'The mother knows the boy ate the bread.'

- The matrix verb agrees with its clausal absolutive complement.

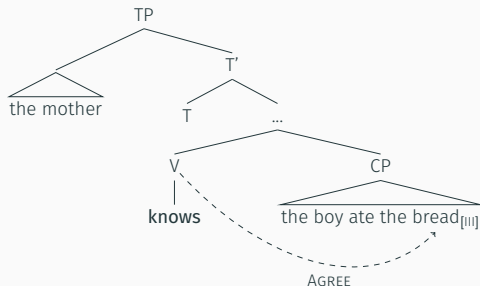


- This is analog to the tree on the previous slide, the only difference is that now the object is a full CP.
- This kind of Agreement is in line with the PIC, because it does not dig beyond CP.

A more puzzling case of “Long Distance” Agreement

- (4) enir [užā magalu bāc’ruḷi] b-iyxo
mother [boy bread.III.ABS ate].IV III-know
‘The mother knows the boy ate the bread.’

- The matrix verb now agrees with an absolutive DP **within the embedded clause!** This DP does not appear to be at the edge of CP (absolutive arguments are low); so this configuration seems to be violating the PIC.



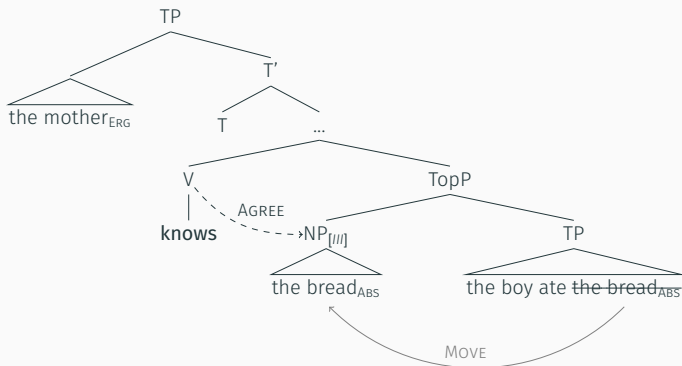
- Additional facts: LDA can *only* target embedded **topics** ($\simeq$ given elements) that are in an **absolutive position**.

Three main workarounds

- The Goal is base-generated in the embedded clause and **covertly moves to its edge, in a specific Topic projection: most likely analysis, we'll focus on this today.**
- Alternative analysis (refuted by P&P, see arguments at the end of this presentation): the Goal is base-generated in the matrix clause as a null element coreferential with its overt counterpart in the embedded clause.
- Alternative analysis (refuted by P&P, see arguments at the end of this presentation): the Goal is base-generated in the embedded clause and moves to the matrix.

The analysis at a glance

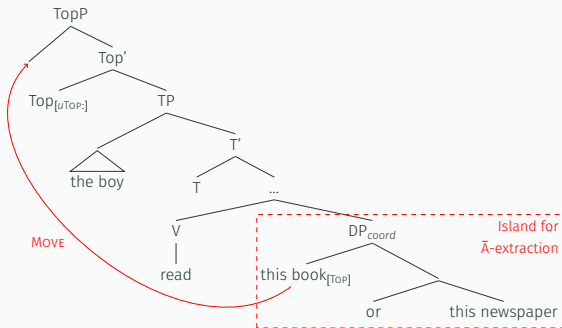
- The Goal is base-generated in the embedded clause and **covertly moves to its edge, in a specific Topic projection**. This is local enough to allow Agreement with the matrix predicate.
- This also explains the topic-restriction of LDA.



LDA and topicalization

Tsez topics

- Tsez has two **topic markers** *-no* and *-gon*.
- These are shown to trigger **topicalization** (an $\bar{A}$ operation), moving the topic-marked element to the edge of the clause.
- **This can happen covertly**; we know because *-no*/*-gon* cannot occur inside islands. This would be weird if movement was absent, but fully expected if movement is present—recall $\bar{A}$ -operations like topicalization are island-sensitive!



Topic-marking forces LDA

- If the embedded absolutive element topic-marked, LDA between this topic and the matrix verb becomes obligatory.

(5) enir [už-ā magalu-(go)n b-āc'ruḷi] b-iyxo
mother boy.ERG bread.**III**.ABS.TOPIC III-eat **III**-know
'About the bread, the mother knows the boy ate it.'

(6) * enir [už-ā magalu-(go)n b-āc'ruḷi] r-iyxo
mother boy.ERG bread.**III**.ABS.**TOPIC** III-eat **IV**-know
Intended: 'About the bread, the mother knows the boy ate it.'

- Given that topic marking (morphology) forces topicalization (movement to the clause edge), **topicalization can be understood as forcing LDA**.
- P&P also show that elements which *cannot* be topics, cannot trigger LDA, strengthening the topic-LDA correlation.

Topicalization of a non-absolutive inhibits LDA

- Suppose a non-absolutive argument of the embedded clause gets topicalized (could be ensured using topic marker *-(go)n*).
- The absolutive argument of the sentence, which is the only suitable Goal for LDA, will *not* be able to undergo topicalization, and will remain too far from the matrix Probe!
- This line of reasoning predicts LDA to be blocked in that scenario: borne out.

- (7) a. eni-r [ħuɫ uʒ-ā magalu b-āc'ruɫi]
 mother.DAT [yesterday boy.ERG bread.**III**.ABS III-eat].**IV**
 r/*b-iyxo
 IV/***III**-knows
 'The mother knows that yesterday the boy ate bread.'

Locality of LDA

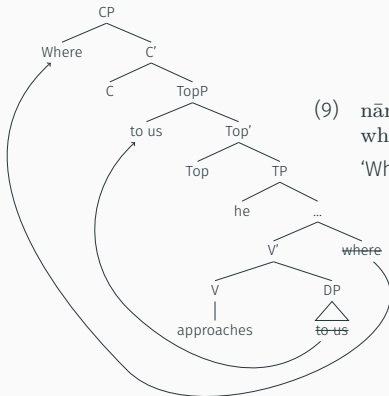
- P&P show independent evidence that $\bar{A}$ -operations in Tsez, including topicalization, are clause-bounded.
- This correctly predicts LDA to be bounded too: **the embedding verb and the embedded absolutive topic cannot be separated by more than one clausal boundary.**

- (8) a. babir [enir [užā magalu bāc'ruḷi] b-iyxosili]
 father [mother [boy bread.III.ABS ate] III-know].IV
 r-iyxo
 IV-know
 'The father knows that the mother knows that the boy ate the bread.'
- b. * babir [enir [užā magalu bāc'ruḷi] b-iyxosili]
 father [mother [boy bread.III.ABS ate] III-know].IV
 r-iyxo
 III-know
 'The father knows that the mother knows that the boy ate the bread.'

LDA and clause size

TopP and CP

- Why not assume that topics move to Spec-CP?
- Overt *wh*-movement and topicalization can occur *together* in Tsez, in which case the fronted *wh*-element precedes the topic.
- This is evidence that CP, if present, dominates TopP. P&P take that **these projections are present iff filled**.



- (9) nār elude-r(-no) ža nex-xo
where we.DAT.(TOP) he.ABS approach
'Where will he approach us?'

LDA blocking by *wh*-words

- Prediction: if the embedded clause has a CP, LDA should not be **possible**, because the absolute Goal would remain unreachable for the matrix Probe.
- One way to make sure a CP is there, is to have a *wh*-word in the clause. P&P have evidence that even if this *wh*-word remains *in situ*, it moves covertly to Spec-CP!

- (10) a. enir [lu micxir b-ok'āk'ruli]
 mother [who.ERG money.III.ABS III-steal].IV
 r-iyxo.
 IV-knows
 'The mother knows who stole the money.'
- b. * enir [lu micxir b-ok'āk'ruli]
 mother [who.ERG money.III.ABS III-steal].IV
 r-iyxo.
 III-knows
 'The mother knows who stole the money.'

LDA blocking by complementizers

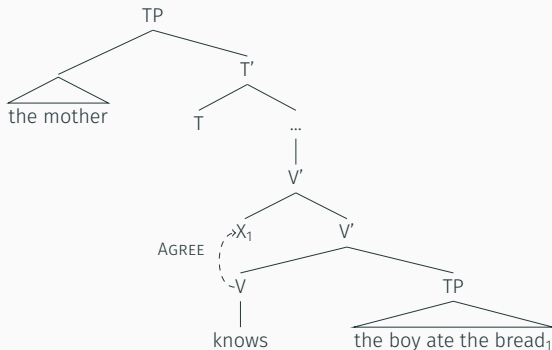
- Prediction: if the embedded clause has a CP, LDA should not be **possible**, because the absolutive Goal would remain unreachable for the matrix Probe.
- Another way to make sure a CP is there, is to have an **overt complementizer**!

- (11) a. eni-r [už-ā magalu b-āc'ruḥi]
 mother.DAT [boy.ERG bread.**III**.ABS III-eat].**IV**
 r/b-iyxo
 IV/III-knows
 'The mother knows the boy ate bread.'
- b. * eni-r [už-ā magalu b-ac'si-**ḥin**]
 mother.DAT [boy.ERG bread.**III**.ABS III-eat-**COMP**].**IV**
 b-iyxo.
 III-knows
 'The mother knows that the boy ate bread.'

Rejecting alternatives analyses

Alternative matrix base-generation approach

- Suppose the Goal is in fact base-generated in the matrix clause as a null element coreferential with its overt counterpart in the embedded clause.
- AGREE can take place in the matrix!



Refuting the matrix base-generation approach

- P&P show the null element X_1 should be a pronoun or anaphor, which would represent an *ad hoc* assumption given general facts about Tsez null pros.
- Analysis incorrectly predicts the matrix Goal to sometimes be overt instead of covert.
- It does not explain why only embedded *absolute* Goals can trigger LDA
- Incorrectly predicts LDA to be clause-unbounded (you can create a chain of coreferential null pros, one per clause).
- Incorrectly predicts scopal interactions between the LDA Goal and matrix subject quantified expressions.
- Incorrectly predicts the LDA Goal to bind matrix anaphors.

Refuting an alternative matrix movement approach

- Suppose the Goal is base-generated in the embedded clause and moves to the matrix.
- This movement cannot be overt, because it would screw up word order.⁸ Additionally, if the embedded clause gets dislocated, the LDA Goal “follows” so it must be part of it.
- This movement cannot be A-movement, because otherwise the ergative DP (higher in the embedded clause) should trigger LDA. Also, it would incorrectly predict the binding/scope interactions pointed out in the previous slide.
- And it cannot be A-bar because there’s independent evidence that A-bar movement in Tsez is clause-bounded. Also, it would incorrectly predict the scope interactions pointed out in the previous slide.

⁸Even given that Tsez allows (clause -internal!) scrambling

Focusing on the scopal interaction counterargument

(12) **Some** teacher likes **every** boy.

There's one teacher that likes every boy ($\exists > \forall$)

For every boy, there's a teacher who likes him ($\forall > \exists$)

- If a quantified absolute topic indeed ends up in the matrix clause, either as a pro or after movement, we expect it to **interact scopally with other quantified expressions in the matrix...**
- Not borne out! The absolute topic can only be interpreted in the scope of a quantified matrix subject. It cannot scope over it.

(13) sis učitelər šibaw užı ø-ik'ixosili ø-iyxo
one teacher every boy-I.ABS I-go I-know

'Some teacher is s.t. they know that every boy is going ($\exists > \forall$).'

*'For every boy, some teacher knows that he's going ($\forall > \exists$).'

References i



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